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THREAT FROM ABOVE

In rural southern Illinois, a cattle farmer fights back against black vultures, birds that can prey on newborn cows and for a long time never settled so far north

By Andrew Carter | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In daylight they move in low, slow circles above the country roads and the cattle farms in rural southern Illinois, outsiders in a continuous migration. They do not fly as much as they glide, at least not while they prey, and when they circle they are searching. Road-kill makes for an easy meal. So do newborn cows, much to the anguish of farmers.

For a long time black vultures never settled so far north. But now they've arrived, and it is for that reason that Patty Zettle, 62, keeps her Benelli Black Eagle 12-gauge at the ready. She is as certain as she can be that black vultures killed one of her calves last year. It had to have happened not long after Black Ruby — and Zettle names her cattle — gave birth.

Zettle discovered the scene only after it was too late:

A mutilated calf with missing eyes. Most of its tongue ripped out. Chunks of its flesh, gone. It's difficult not to become attached to the newborns and their mothers and the thought that Black Ruby's baby died in such a way has left Zettle haunted. It was a loss, too, of upward of \$2,000 — no insignificant sum for a small-time cow-calf operation with tight margins.

In the aftermath, Zettle made a likeness of a black vulture out of wire and cloth and hung it on a tree.

"That's my effigy," she said matter-of-factly one morning in late May, pointing it out while she moved her cows from one pasture to another. Among all she'd learned about black vultures, that was among the most valuable: They do not like effigies.

Zettle climbed out of her farm cart and unhooked the dummy bird from a branch. She scooted along through the tall grass and clumps of mud and secured it to another tree in the field where she'd led her cows, guiding them along by name — Millie, the matriarch, and Funny Face, with the specks around her muzzle — and gentle reassurance.

"Come on, girls," Zettle said, and they slowly ambled through the paddock in a bellowing chorus of moos. Soon they were all together, with a healthy pasture to graze upon and the fake vulture to stand guard

See **VULTURES** on Page A4

Above: Robert Willmore and fiancée Patty Zettle hang a dead black vulture in a tree on Zettle's farm near Thompsonville, Ill., on May 19, in hopes of scaring black vultures away from her cows **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE**

Benton's actions known years ago

Speaker's office told of other harassment claims against disgraced ex-state representative

By Jeremy Gornier and Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — When he detailed the steps his office took that led state Rep. Harry Benton to resign his seat amid allegations of sexual harassment, House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch praised those who "trusted our office to listen, support them and ensure their concerns were handled appropriately."

"Allegations of misconduct are taken with the utmost seriousness," Welch said, revealing that an investigation by state Legislative Inspector General Michael McCuskey found Benton displayed "clear patterns of conduct" that were "outrageous, unethical and unbecoming of a member" of the House.

"We have a process that's in place that I believe is a good process," Welch told reporters at an unrelated press conference in Chicago following the Plainfield Democrat's resignation earlier this month. "They trusted us to have procedures in place that would protect them, protect their confidentiality and we had a process in place that guaranteed due process of the accused."

But Welch's account of his office's swift response stands in sharp contrast to what happened three years ago. That's when a young female Benton staffer — one of his first hires whose interactions with the lawmaker were part of the investigation — outlined a lengthy series of harassment allegations, many of a sexual nature, to Welch's office.

Back then, the speaker's office slow-walked the case after the woman reported the harassment allegations to the speaker's then-chief of staff in April 2023, the Tribune found.

Benton wasn't interviewed by the speaker's top staff until three months later, in July 2023, according to calendar records obtained by the Tribune. That was after the woman had already quit her job, saying she feared for her mental health. According to the former staffer, Benton was not disciplined at the time.

In a pair of statements in response to questions from the Tribune, Welch's office defended its handling of the case, saying it acted "promptly" and said "appropriate action was taken" — though the statements did not specify what, if any,



Benton

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Bike lane ticketing program records big fines against delivery companies

City has issued nearly \$2.6M in penalties since program's creation

By A.D. Quig and Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A bike lane ticketing program meant to make busy downtown streets safer for cyclists and pedestrians has found package delivery giants are among its most consistent scoff-laws, news that will not come as a surprise to Chicagoans used to seeing trucks and vans idling throughout the Loop.

The city issues warnings and tickets to bike and bus lane blockers as part of its "Smart Streets" pilot program. Cameras mounted on city vehicles and Chicago Transit Authority buses capture the obstructions, and tickets are issued by the city's Department of Finance.

Roughly a year and a half since the

program's creation, the city has issued tens of thousands of warnings and citations under the program and has issued nearly \$2.6 million in fines to impiders of bike lanes, bus lanes and bus stops, not counting late fees, according to data received via an open records request from the city's Department of Finance.

Vehicles owned by Amazon Logistics, FedEx and UPS were charged a combined \$460,000 for bus stop, bus lane and bike lane violations between November 2024 and early this May, according to the data.

That doesn't count independent contractors that work with those companies but use their own vehicles, or major firms that contract with the corporate giants for things like last mile delivery. Companies like Trans One Inc. and Northwest Express

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An Amazon delivery truck is parked in a bus lane on South Dearborn Street near West Van Buren Street in the Loop on July 9. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



SPORTS

Still the toast of the town

Celebrating the World Series-winning 2016 Cubs never gets old at Wrigley Field, even as the players do, writes Paul Sullivan.

ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT

Conductor takes a bow

The barrier-breaking Marin Alsop is leaving Ravinia after six years as chief conductor and a one-time curator of the festival.

NATION & WORLD

US troops killed in attack

The U.S. military said Saturday two troops were killed and another is missing after an attack by Iran on a base in Jordan. **Page B5**

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